

Lesson 2: How Did We Get Here?

Christina Reckard

So, when it comes to women in the workplace, “How did we get here?”

That is an excellent question. The last century has seen a *remarkable* transformation in the role of women in the U.S. workforce.

At the beginning of the 20th century, the role of women in the workforce was largely restricted to a handful of careers such as teaching, nursing, and domestic work. Social expectations and legal rules limited women’s employment opportunities and rights.

World War I in the early 20th century marked a pivotal moment. With millions of men deployed overseas, women began filling roles in factories, offices, and other industries essential to the war effort. This shift demonstrated women's capabilities beyond traditional domestic roles and laid the groundwork for change.

The passage of the 19th Amendment in 1920 granted women the right to vote, symbolizing greater political and social empowerment. Women increasingly entered the workforce, particularly in clerical positions, thanks to the expanding economy and technological advancements like the typewriter.

However, the Great Depression of the 1930s brought severe economic hardship, leading to widespread job losses. During this period, societal attitudes hardened against working women, especially married women, who were often seen as taking jobs from men and time from their children. Despite this, many women continued to work out of necessity – often in poorly paid positions.

World War II was another turning point. As millions of men went to war, women once again stepped into roles traditionally held by men. The image of "Rosie the Riveter" became iconic, symbolizing women's contributions to the war effort as factory workers, engineers, and in other critical positions. By 1945, women made up nearly 37% of the U.S. workforce, a 10% jump in just five years.

The 1950s saw a return to traditional gender roles, but the 60s brought significant social upheaval and the official rise of the women's liberation movement. This decade was marked by landmark legislation aimed at reducing gender discrimination, such as The Equal Pay Act of 1963 and the Civil Rights Act of 1964, which prohibited employment discrimination based on race, color, religion, sex, or nationality.

The 1970s – around the time Pat herself first entered the workforce – saw a substantial increase in the number of women entering higher education and the professional job market. The 1980s continued this trend, with women increasingly entering more advanced professions such as law, medicine, and business. However, this decade also highlighted ongoing challenges. The term "glass ceiling" was coined – an invisible barrier preventing women from reaching top executive positions – and it became a prominent issue. Women also faced challenges related to work-life balance as they juggled professional responsibilities and family duties.

The 1990s, around when Pat hit her stride as a coach, was marked by significant growth in women's professional achievements. Women began to occupy prominent leadership roles in politics, sports, and the decade also saw the implementation of family-friendly policies in many workplaces like The Family and Medical Leave Act (FMLA) of 1993.

Yet in spite of all of this growth, a myriad of stereotypes and biases still plagued women in the workforce. While women were catching up educationally and legally, the old attitudes and traditions of corporate America were slow to adjust. The perception of what was a “woman’s work” and what was “male work” still persisted. *Were* women just as ambitious as men? *Did* they have the necessary leadership skills?

And that brings us to where we are today, examining more of the landscape of the modern workplace and the obstacles facing female leaders. As we look to the future, continued advocacy, policy changes, and cultural shifts are necessary to ensure women can fully and equally participate in and benefit from the workforce.

Let’s learn more!